PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz G 500

1998–2008 · W463 · M113 5.0 V8

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Test all three locking differentials**
  Engage each lock on a loose surface and watch the indicators. Lockers that ‘were never used’ by the last owner often don’t work — budget for the vacuum diagnosis below.
- [ ] **Is it really an AMG?**
  Plenty of standard Gs have been dressed as AMGs. Check the VIN and data card against the badges before paying an AMG premium.
- [ ] **Work every window, lock and seat**
  Especially on 2002–04 trucks. Handsome Motors lists seat motors and controls, window regulators and motors, and door-lock actuators as the early trucks' electrical gremlins, along with the transfer-case actuator. Try every switch, every door from inside and out, and shift the transfer case.
- [ ] **Listen at idle**
  Vibration or a chirp that changes with revs on an M113 points at the harmonic balancer — a known failure on early-2000s Mercedes V8s.
- [ ] **Look for oil on top of the engine**
  Wetness at the front of the V points at the oil filter housing seals; oil on the coil packs and exhaust manifolds points at valve cover gaskets or breather hoses. Neither is serious if fixed early, and both are reasonable DIY jobs (see repairs).
- [ ] **Look behind the front wheels**
  Gear oil on the inside of the wheels or the brake calipers means leaking front axle seals — and possibly contaminated brakes.
- [ ] **Drive it at 55–70 mph**
  Wander or steering shake at highway speed usually means a tired steering damper and worn linkage.
- [ ] **Rust where nobody cleans**
  Check the tailgate’s lower edge, door bottoms, sills, rear frame tubes, inner wheel arches and around the rear bumper.
- [ ] **A sagging headliner means water**
  Usually blocked sunroof drains. Water can reach the fuse box and climate actuators, so check those too.

YEARS TO KNOW

2002–04	BEWARE	Early US trucks have the electrical gremlins: Handsome Motors lists seat motors and controls, window regulators and motors, door-lock actuators and transfer-case actuators. Expedition Portal owners say the same about 2002–03

2005–08	SWEET SPOT	The sweet spot. Handsome Motors says the early electrical faults got better every year and were mostly gone by 2005–06. 2005–06 trucks keep the simpler five-speed 722.6; 2007–08 trucks get the seven-speed 7G-TRONIC, HID lamps and a reversing camera

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Front turn signals behind grille cover don't meet FMVSS 108**
  2002–2008 (campaign covers 2002–2010 G-Class) · NHTSA 10V366000
- ☐ **Incorrect software calibration (SCN) coding after a workshop visit**
  2003 · NHTSA 08V303000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **US VIN**
  Mercedes-Benz USA G 500s (2002–2008) start WDCYR49E; NHTSA's decoder reads that as a G-Class with a 5.0-litre engine built in Graz. Position 10 is the model year and position 11 is X for the Graz plant. A 2003 G 55 AMG reads WDCYR46E instead.
- ☐ **Europa trucks**
  1998–2001 trucks sold by Europa International carry US VINs issued by Europa, not Mercedes. NHTSA's decoder flags one BaT-sold 2001 G 500 Europa VIN (WDBEG4213Z7122501) as non-standard, so expect the import paperwork to tell the story.
- ☐ **Fake AMGs**
  Bumpers, flares, wheels and badges bolt straight on, and Autocar warns about Gs converted to look like AMGs. Check that the VIN and factory data card agree with what's on the tailgate.
- ☐ **Factory data card**
  Mercedes-Benz Classic sells a digital vehicle data card for most passenger cars built 1986–2010 (AMG models excluded). It lists the model, original option codes, paint and trim, costs €130, and requires proof of ownership.
- ☐ **Gearbox**
  The five-speed 722.6 ran until June 2006 production; the seven-speed 722.9 (7G-TRONIC) followed, which in the US means 2002–2006 model years are five-speeds and 2007–2008 are seven-speeds. Check the VIN model year, the build month on the door-jamb label, and the dipstick: the 722.6 has one, the 722.9 does not. That matters for fluid specs and service intervals.

- [ ] **Three lockers**
  All three locks are worked from the dash buttons and engage in sequence: centre, then rear, then front. If a light won't go solid, suspect the vacuum side before the axle.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/g-class/g500/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks